

# American BBQ Smokehouse

*Lunch & Dinner — 11:00am to 9:00pm*

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

Low and slow. Post oak smoke. The bark, the ring, the pull. BBQ done right takes 12 hours — and it shows.

POST OAK · 225°F · 12 HOURS

48

SEATS

\$52

AVG SPEND

28%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$70,624

EST. MONTHLY NET

**The Holy Trinity of American BBQ:** Brisket, ribs, and pulled pork are the pillars of serious American barbecue — a cuisine built on patience, fire management, and an almost obsessive relationship with smoke. The **low-and-slow** method (225–250°F / 107–121°C for 10–16 hours) transforms tough, collagen-rich cuts into fork-tender masterpieces by converting connective tissue (collagen) to gelatin over time. This is BBQ science, not BBQ romance. The **smoke ring** — that pink layer beneath the bark — is formed when nitric oxide from burning wood reacts with myoglobin in the meat, creating metmyoglobin that stays pink even when fully cooked. The **bark** — the dark, crusty exterior — is the Maillard reaction combined with smoke particulates, salt, pepper, and rendered fat binding together over 12+ hours. No shortcut produces it. The **stall** (160–170°F internal temp) is evaporative cooling as intramuscular fat begins to render — the brisket can sit at this temperature for 2–4 hours. Understanding these three phenomena separates a genuine pitmaster from someone with a smoker. Your guests will taste the difference, and that is your competitive moat.

## THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

**"I set my alarm for 4:45am every single day. I have never once hit snooze. That is how you know you are doing the right thing."**

Travis had been competing in BBQ competitions in Texas since he was 27. He had trophies. He had 4,000 Instagram followers who watched his smoke-ring reveals every weekend. He had a brisket technique that had placed in the top three at eleven regional competitions and won one outright. What he did not have was a restaurant — because he understood, correctly, that the gap between competition BBQ and restaurant BBQ is enormous and unforgiving.

Competition BBQ is about one perfect brisket, cooked once, judged by experts with calibrated palates. Restaurant BBQ is about thirty briskets, cooked every single day, served to customers who paid \$28 and are expecting the best brisket of their lives — and who will leave a one-star review if the flat is dry, the bark is soft, or the smoke ring is absent. The consistency requirement is categorically different from the perfection requirement. Travis knew this. It kept him from starting for three years.

The guide's section on the stall — the plateau at 160–170F where evaporative

cooling matches the heat input and the brisket stops rising in temperature for two to three hours — was the operational description he had never found written down clearly. He knew the stall from experience. The guide told him how to build it into a restaurant schedule: start at 5am, expect the stall at 10am, wrap or wait based on bark development, pull at 203F, rest minimum 90 minutes. Repeatably. Every day.

He opened in Round Rock, Texas. The smoke reaches the road. He sold out of brisket three days in the first week. He adjusted volume. He has not sold out since. The Pitmaster platter — full rack, brisket, sausage — is his highest-revenue item and his most effective marketing. Month four net: \$64,000.

**Great BBQ does not need sauce. Great BBQ does not need advertising. It needs the smoke to reach the street.**

**Travis W. · American BBQ Smokehouse · Round Rock, Texas · Est. Month 4 Net: \$64,000**

1 Entrées

Burnt Ends — Brisket Point, 6 Pieces

Caramelised brisket point cubes, house BBQ glaze, pickles · Sell: \$14.99

3 min plate

Entrée

Target FC: 26%

INGREDIENTS (6-PIECE SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                        | WEIGHT | COST   |
|-----------------------------------|--------|--------|
| Brisket point (pre-smoked, cubed) | 200g   | \$2.43 |
| Brown sugar                       | 20g    | \$0.04 |
| House BBQ sauce (batch)           | 40ml   | \$0.18 |
| Apple cider vinegar               | 10ml   | \$0.03 |
| Unsalted butter                   | 15g    | \$0.08 |
| Bread & butter pickles (garnish)  | 20g    | \$0.06 |
| Toasted sesame bun (side)         | 1 pc   | \$0.18 |
| Total cost per serve              |        | \$3.00 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$3.00  |
| Sell price          | \$14.99 |
| Food cost %         | 20.0%   |
| Contribution margin | \$11.99 |

METHOD

- 1 Source the point correctly:** Burnt ends come from the *point* (deckle) of the brisket — the fatty, thicker end, not the flat. The point has more intramuscular fat (marbling) and connective tissue, which means it survives double cooking without drying out. After the primary 12-hour smoke, separate point from flat by cutting through the natural fat seam. The point should be deeply barked and yielding. Internal temp should already be at **203°F / 95°C**.
- 2 Cube and toss:** Cut point into 1.5-inch cubes. The cube size is intentional — large enough to retain moisture through the second cook, small enough to develop crust on all six sides. Toss with brown sugar, a splash of apple cider vinegar, and half the BBQ sauce. The vinegar cuts richness; the sugar creates caramelisation in the second cook. Do not skip either.
- 3 Second smoke/oven:** Place cubes on a wire rack or in a cast iron skillet. Return to smoker at

**275°F / 135°C** uncovered for 60–90 minutes, or finish in a 300°F convection oven. The goal is to render any remaining fat and create a sticky, lacquered bark on all surfaces. Stir once at 45 minutes and add remaining sauce + butter. The butter emulsifies with the rendered fat to create a glossy, clingy glaze.

- 4 Plate immediately:** Burnt ends are best served the moment they come out of the second cook — the crust firms as they cool. 6 cubes per portion, sauce spooned over, pickles on the side to cut the richness. If prepping in advance, hold in a covered hotel pan with a thin layer of warm sauce at **140°F / 60°C** for service. Do not hold longer than 90 minutes or the crust softens.

**Chef's Tip:** Burnt ends are a *by-product of the brisket programme* — you cannot make them without running a full brisket operation. They are however one of your highest-margin and most emotionally compelling items. When a table orders burnt ends as a starter, the pitmaster story is already being told before the main arrives. Never skip them from the menu.

GLUTEN (bun)   DAIRY (butter)   SOY (BBQ sauce may contain)

## Jalapeño Cheddar Cornbread — 2 Pieces

Cast iron skillet cornbread, sharp cheddar, fresh jalapeño, honey butter · Sell: \$6.99

5 min plate   Entrée / Side   Target FC: 18%

### INGREDIENTS (1 BATCH / 12 PIECES)

| INGREDIENT                                   | WEIGHT      | COST                   |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------|------------------------|
| Yellow cornmeal (stone-ground)               | 240g        | \$0.63                 |
| All-purpose flour                            | 120g        | \$0.08                 |
| Sharp cheddar, shredded                      | 150g        | \$1.65                 |
| Fresh jalapeños, diced                       | 60g         | \$0.27                 |
| Buttermilk                                   | 300ml       | \$0.45                 |
| Eggs                                         | 2 × 55g     | \$0.70                 |
| Unsalted butter                              | 60g         | \$0.33                 |
| Sugar, baking powder, salt                   | misc        | \$0.10                 |
| Honey butter (serve)                         | 15g/portion | \$0.09                 |
| <b>Batch cost (12 pcs) · 2-pc serve cost</b> |             | <b>\$4.30 · \$0.72</b> |

|                            |               |
|----------------------------|---------------|
| Cost per 2-piece serve     | \$0.72        |
| Sell price                 | \$6.99        |
| Food cost %                | 10.3%         |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$6.27</b> |

### METHOD

- 1 Cast iron prep — the non-negotiable:** Preheat your cast iron skillet in a 425°F oven for 10 minutes before adding batter. The screaming-hot skillet creates an instant crust on the bottom — the hallmark of proper skillet cornbread. A cold pan produces steamed, not seared cornbread. Grease with bacon fat or butter just before pouring batter.
- 2 Wet/dry method:** Whisk dry ingredients (cornmeal, flour, baking powder, sugar, salt) separately from wet (buttermilk, eggs, melted butter). Combine with minimal strokes — overmixing develops gluten and makes cornbread tough. Fold in cheddar and jalapeño at the last moment. The buttermilk provides acid that reacts with baking powder for lift and adds a subtle tang that balances the rich cheddar.
- 3 Bake at 425°F / 218°C for 18–22 minutes** until golden, pulling away at edges, and a skewer comes out clean. The crust should be deep golden and crunchy. Internal temp target: **200°F / 93°C**. Do not underbake — a gummy centre is a quality failure. The cheese pockets should be melted and slightly caramelised at the surface.
- 4 Portion and hold:** Cut into 12 wedges per 10-inch skillet. Batch-bake in the morning and hold cut

wedges in a hotel pan, uncovered, at room temperature. For service, heat wedge on a dry griddle 90 seconds per side (creates re-crisped exterior). Serve with honey butter (equal parts honey + softened butter, whipped). The hot cornbread + cold honey butter = signature experience.

**Chef's Tip:** Stone-ground cornmeal (not fine-ground commercial) produces superior flavour and texture — the coarser grind gives cornbread its characteristic slightly gritty, rustic texture. Source from regional mills where possible. The jalapeño heat level should be noticeable but not aggressive — remove seeds for a milder version and always disclose heat level to guests.

GLUTEN

DAIRY

EGGS

## Smoked Wings — 6 Pieces, Dry Rub

Whole chicken wings, house dry rub, smoked 2 hours, finished on grill · Sell: \$13.99

5 min plate

Entrée

Target FC: 24%

### INGREDIENTS (6-WING SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                                                                                 | WEIGHT           | COST          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|---------------|
| Whole chicken wings (tips on)                                                              | 480g (~6 wings)  | \$2.99        |
| House dry rub (paprika, brown sugar, garlic, pepper, salt, cayenne, cumin, mustard powder) | 18g              | \$0.14        |
| Oak/hickory wood chunks                                                                    | 60g (smoke fuel) | \$0.05        |
| House ranch dipping sauce                                                                  | 40ml             | \$0.15        |
| Celery sticks, blue cheese crumble                                                         | 30g / 10g        | \$0.12        |
| <b>Total cost per serve</b>                                                                |                  | <b>\$3.45</b> |

|                            |                |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$3.45         |
| Sell price                 | \$13.99        |
| Food cost %                | 24.7%          |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$10.54</b> |

### METHOD

- 1 Dry brine with rub — 4 hours minimum:** Apply dry rub generously to wings, coating all surfaces. Refrigerate uncovered for at least 4 hours (overnight preferred). The salt in the rub draws moisture to the surface, which then reabsorbs, seasoning the meat deeply. Uncovered refrigeration also dries the skin surface — essential for achieving crispy skin in a low-heat smoker environment.
- 2 Smoke at 225°F / 107°C for 90-120 minutes:** Arrange wings on grates with space between each. Use a blend of hickory and fruit wood (apple or cherry) — hickory alone can be too aggressive on chicken; the fruit wood adds sweetness and lighter smoke. Wings should reach **165°F / 74°C** internal at the thickest point of the drumette. The skin will not be crispy at this stage — that comes next.
- 3 Finish on high-heat grill for crispiness:** Transfer smoked wings to a 450°F+ grill or broiler for 3-4 minutes per side. This is the critical step — the smoke phase flavours and cooks the meat, but only intense radiant heat renders the subcutaneous fat and crisps the skin. Without this step you have rubbery-skin smoked wings. With it, you have the best of both worlds: smoke flavour + crispy exterior.
- 4 Hold and plate:** Batch-smoke wings in the morning. Hold pre-grilled in a hotel pan at **140°F / 60°C**. Fire the grill finish to order (3-4 min). This two-stage process means you can service wings in under 5 minutes during a rush while still delivering proper smoked flavour. Plate 6 wings, ranch on the side, celery, and blue cheese crumble.

**Chef's Tip:** The house dry rub ratio: 3 parts paprika, 2 parts brown sugar, 2 parts kosher salt, 1 part black pepper, 1 part garlic powder, ½ part cayenne, ½ part cumin, ½ part dry mustard. Make this in 1kg batches. The brown sugar contributes to Maillard browning and bark formation.

It will char slightly on the grill finish — this is correct and desirable.

DAIRY (blue cheese)   EGGS (ranch)   MUSTARD (rub)

## House-Made Coleslaw

Creamy apple cider vinegar slaw, green and purple cabbage, carrot · Sell: \$4.99

2 min plate   Side / Entrée   Target FC: 12%

### INGREDIENTS (BATCH / 20 SERVES)

| INGREDIENT                             | WEIGHT | COST            |
|----------------------------------------|--------|-----------------|
| Green cabbage, shredded                | 800g   | \$1.06          |
| Purple cabbage, shredded               | 400g   | \$0.53          |
| Carrot, julienned                      | 200g   | \$0.18          |
| Mayonnaise                             | 200g   | \$0.55          |
| Apple cider vinegar                    | 40ml   | \$0.10          |
| Celery seed, sugar, salt, black pepper | misc   | \$0.08          |
| Batch cost · Per serve (80g)           |        | \$2.50 · \$0.13 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$0.13 |
| Sell price          | \$4.99 |
| Food cost %         | 2.6%   |
| Contribution margin | \$4.86 |

### METHOD

- 1 Salt-wilt for crunch:** Toss shredded cabbage with 1 tsp kosher salt, let stand 15 minutes, then squeeze out excess moisture. This draws out water that would otherwise dilute your dressing and make the slaw watery within the hour. Salt-wilted cabbage retains its crunch for 4–6 hours dressed; unsalted cabbage turns limp within 30 minutes.
- 2 Dress with restraint:** Combine mayonnaise, apple cider vinegar, celery seed, sugar, salt, and pepper. The ratio matters: this should be a lightly dressed slaw, not a mayo-heavy one. Too much mayo makes it cloying against rich BBQ; the vinegar acidity is what makes slaw work as a palate cleanser alongside fatty brisket and pork.
- 3 Toss and rest 30 minutes:** Combine dressed cabbage and carrot. Rest in refrigerator 30 minutes before service. This allows the dressing to penetrate the cabbage and flavours to meld. Taste and adjust seasoning — the slaw should be noticeably tangy, lightly sweet, and well-seasoned. A bland slaw is a missed opportunity.
- 4 Batch management:** Prep 2 batches daily — a morning batch (for lunch service) and an afternoon batch (for dinner). Do not carry slaw from lunch to dinner; dressed cabbage past 4 hours becomes limp and watery. Undressed shredded cabbage keeps refrigerated for 2 days. The fresh daily batch is a quality marker customers will notice.

**Chef's Tip:** The coleslaw's job on a BBQ tray is textural and acid contrast. It should be cold, crunchy, and tangy. Serve it cold — room temperature slaw is unpleasant. Position it adjacent to the meat so guests can alternate bites. The crunch-to-fat ratio is what makes the combination work neurologically.

EGGS (mayo)   MUSTARD (mayo may contain)

## Smokehouse Baked Beans

Navy beans, smoked brisket trimmings, molasses, brown sugar, tomato · Sell: \$5.99

3 min plate   Side / Entrée   Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (BATCH / 16 SERVES)

| INGREDIENT                                   | WEIGHT          | COST            |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|
| Canned navy beans (drained)                  | 1,200g (3 cans) | \$4.86          |
| Brisket trimmings / burnt end scraps         | 200g            | \$1.21          |
| Tomato paste + diced tomato                  | 60g + 200g      | \$0.55          |
| Molasses                                     | 60ml            | \$0.22          |
| Brown sugar                                  | 40g             | \$0.07          |
| Apple cider vinegar, mustard, Worcestershire | misc            | \$0.18          |
| Onion, garlic                                | 100g / 20g      | \$0.14          |
| Batch cost · Per serve (130g)                |                 | \$7.23 · \$0.45 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$0.45 |
| Sell price          | \$5.99 |
| Food cost %         | 7.5%   |
| Contribution margin | \$5.54 |

METHOD

- 1

**Use brisket by-product:** The brisket trimming programme (fat cap removal, point separation) generates 300–500g of usable meat scraps and fat per brisket. These go into the beans. Render the fat pieces in a heavy pot first to release fat for sautéing onion and garlic. Add diced trimming meat. This zero-waste practice also delivers genuine smoked meat flavour into the beans — not simulated.
- 2

**Build the sauce:** After softening onion and garlic in brisket fat, add tomato paste and cook 2 minutes (caramelises the tomato, removes raw flavour). Add diced tomato, molasses, brown sugar, apple cider vinegar, dry mustard, Worcestershire. The molasses is non-negotiable — it gives baked beans their distinctive dark, slightly bitter-sweet depth. White sugar alone produces a one-dimensional sweetness.
- 3

**Low-slow braise 2–3 hours:** Add drained beans, stir to coat. Cover and cook at low simmer (or put the whole pot in the smoker at 250°F for maximum smoke flavour) for 2–3 hours. Liquid should reduce to a thick, almost jammy sauce that coats the beans. If too thick, add small amounts of water. Taste frequently — adjust acid/sweet balance before service.
- 4

**Batch hold and reheat:** Baked beans hold excellently — make a full batch daily and hold in a hotel pan at **140°F / 60°C**. They improve on day 2 as flavours meld. Reheat to order (scoop 130g, microwave 90 seconds, or ladle from steam table). Garnish with a sliver of smoked jalapeño or crumbled crispy bacon for visual appeal and flavour pop.

**Chef's Tip:** The secret to great smokehouse beans is genuine smoked meat fat. The smoky rendered fat from brisket trimmings infuses the beans in a way that no liquid smoke ever replicates. This dish is literally built on the brisket programme's by-products — zero additional protein cost. As a standalone side dish, this is one of your highest-margin items on the menu.

GLUTEN (Worcestershire)

FISH (Worcestershire)

MUSTARD

CELERY

Pickled Jalapeños + Bread & Butter Pickles

House-brined condiment plate, essential table-side palate cleansers · Sell: \$3.99

1 min plate

Condiment

Target FC: 10%

INGREDIENTS (BATCH / 30 SERVES)

| INGREDIENT                          | WEIGHT     | COST   |
|-------------------------------------|------------|--------|
| Fresh jalapeños, sliced             | 400g       | \$1.78 |
| Cucumbers (Kirby/pickling), sliced  | 600g       | \$0.80 |
| White vinegar + apple cider vinegar | 500ml each | \$1.40 |

Sugar, kosher salt, turmeric, mustard seed, celery seed

misc

\$0.45

Batch cost · Per serve (50g plate)

\$4.43 · \$0.15

Cost per serve

\$0.15

Sell price

\$3.99

Food cost %

3.8%

Contribution margin

\$3.84

METHOD

1

**Bread & Butter Pickles:** Slice cucumbers ¼-inch thick. Toss with salt, rest 1 hour, rinse and squeeze dry. Prepare brine: equal parts white vinegar and water, sugar to taste (these should be sweet-tart), turmeric (colour), mustard seed, celery seed. Boil brine, pour over packed cucumbers in sterilized jars. Refrigerate 24 hours minimum. The overnight rest allows the spices to bloom and the cucumbers to absorb the brine fully.

2

**Pickled Jalapeños:** Slice jalapeños into ¼-inch rounds. Brine: apple cider vinegar + water (2:1), salt, garlic cloves, a pinch of sugar (less sweet than the bread & butter pickles — jalapeños should be tangy and hot, not sweet). Pack tightly, pour hot brine, seal and refrigerate. Ready in 12 hours; best after 48 hours. The jalapeños maintain crunch for up to 2 weeks refrigerated.

3

**Batch schedule:** Produce both pickle types twice weekly. Label with date. The condiment plate serves as both a palate cleanser and a menu item that signals house-made quality to guests. Most BBQ joints use commercial pickles — yours being house-brined is a differentiator worth mentioning in service scripts.

4

**Plate presentation:** Serve on a small board or two-section ramekin — pickled jalapeños one side, bread & butter pickles the other. Include a small card noting they are house-brined. Temperature: serve cold, straight from refrigerator. Cold pickles against hot smoked meat is a fundamental flavour contrast that refreshes the palate between bites of fat-rich proteins.

**Chef's Tip:** These pickles are the unsung heroes of your BBQ programme. The acid cuts through brisket fat, resets the palate, and adds brightness to an otherwise deeply savoury flavour profile. Always include a few pieces on every platter, even if not ordered separately — the cost is negligible and the impact on the eating experience is significant.

MUSTARD (seeds)

CELERY (seeds)

2

Mains

Texas Brisket — 12-Hour Smoked, Sliced 200g

USDA Choice packer brisket, post oak smoke, salt & pepper rub (SPG), sliced to order · Sell: \$26.99

12 hrs smoke + 5 min plate

Main Feature

Target FC: 30%

INGREDIENTS (PER 200G SERVE, FROM WHOLE PACKER)

| INGREDIENT                                  | WEIGHT                  | COST   |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------|
| USDA Choice packer brisket (raw, 6–7kg)     | 200g served (from ~6kg) | \$6.05 |
| Kosher salt + coarse black pepper (SPG rub) | 12g per kg raw          | \$0.08 |
| Post oak / white oak wood chunks            | 600g fuel per smoke     | \$0.53 |
| Butcher paper (for wrapping)                | 1 sheet                 | \$0.04 |
| White bread (Texas tradition, side)         | 2 slices                | \$0.12 |
| Total cost per serve                        |                         | \$6.82 |

Cost per serve

\$6.82

Sell price

\$26.99

Food cost %

25.3%

Contribution margin

\$20.17

METHOD — THE COMPLETE 12-HOUR PROTOCOL

- 1

**Trim and rub (night before, 8pm):** Trim fat cap to ¼-inch. Thicker fat cap insulates — useful for long smoking — but over ¾-inch means too much rendered fat that cannot evaporate and instead pools, inhibiting bark formation. Leave the fat cap facing up for the first stage of the smoke (protects the flat's lean muscle from direct heat drying). Apply SPG rub generously (salt + coarse black pepper, 50/50 by volume, optionally garlic powder). Let rest uncovered in walk-in overnight — this dries the surface slightly, aiding bark development. **SMOKE SCIENCE** The Maillard reaction requires a dry surface. A wet brisket entering a smoker will steam rather than crust.
- 2

**Smoker at 225-250°F / 107-121°C, post oak, 5am start:** Load smoker with post oak. Post oak is the canonical Texas brisket wood — it burns clean and long, producing a medium-weight smoke that penetrates without overwhelming. Hickory is heavier and better for pork; mesquite burns too hot and acrid for a 12-hour cook. Maintain fire temperature at 225-250°F — this range is where collagen converts to gelatin at the rate required without surface drying. Place brisket fat-side up. The smoke ring (nitric oxide + myoglobin reaction) forms in the first 4 hours only — once internal temp exceeds **140°F / 60°C**, the ring stops developing. This is why initial low temperatures matter for smoke ring depth. **SMOKE RING SCIENCE**
- 3

**Managing the stall (160-170°F internal, typically 10am-12pm):** At approximately **160°F / 71°C** internal temperature, the brisket will stop rising in temperature and may hold there for 2-4 hours. This is called the stall, and it happens because intramuscular moisture evaporates from the meat surface at the same rate as the smoker adds heat — effectively, the brisket is sweating and cooling itself. New pitmasters panic and raise the temperature; experienced ones wait. **The Texas Crutch (optional wrap):** If timing is critical, wrap the brisket tightly in pink (unwaxed) butcher paper at 165°F. Butcher paper allows some steam to escape (unlike foil, which steams and softens bark) while retaining moisture and accelerating the temperature climb through the stall. Post-wrap, temperature will climb 1-2°F per 15 minutes. Target final internal: **203°F / 95°C**. **STALL SCIENCE**
- 4

**Rest 1-2 hours before slicing:** Remove brisket from smoker when probe slides in with zero resistance at **203°F / 95°C** (use a Thermapen in the thickest part of the flat — the point is always hotter). Wrap in a fresh sheet of butcher paper, place in an empty cooler, and rest minimum 1 hour (2 preferred). Resting allows muscle fibers to reabsorb the juices released during cooking — cutting too early means all that moisture runs out on the cutting board. **Slice across the grain in ¼-inch slices** — cutting with the grain produces long, chewy strands; across the grain cuts the fibers short for tenderness. The flat and point have grains running different directions — separate them and slice each correctly. Serve on butcher paper with white bread and pickles: Texas BBQ tradition.

**Chef's Tip:** A good brisket cook requires 2 things above all else: patience and a calibrated thermometer. The 203°F target is not about time — it is about collagen conversion, which is complete when the probe meets zero resistance (the "probe slide" or "butter test"). Some briskets hit this at 195°F; some need 210°F. The number is a guide; the feel is the truth. Invest in a good wireless meat thermometer so your pitmaster can monitor remotely without opening the smoker (every opening loses 15°F and 15-20 minutes of recovery time).

GLUTEN (white bread) CELERY (rub may contain)

St. Louis Spare Ribs — Half Rack

5-6 bone half rack, dry rub bark, 5-hour smoke, unwrapped finish - Sell: \$28.99

5 hrs smoke + 5 min plate Main Target FC: 27%

INGREDIENTS (HALF RACK / 5-6 BONES)

| INGREDIENT                          | WEIGHT          | COST   |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------|--------|
| St. Louis spare ribs (trimmed rack) | ~700g half rack | \$6.95 |
| House dry rub                       | 25g             | \$0.18 |
| Apple cider vinegar (spritz)        | 50ml spray      | \$0.07 |
| Post oak + cherry wood              | 400g fuel       | \$0.35 |
| House BBQ sauce (side)              | 40ml            | \$0.18 |



Total cost per serve \$7.73

|                            |                |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$7.73         |
| Sell price                 | \$28.99        |
| Food cost %                | 26.7%          |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$21.26</b> |

#### METHOD

- 1 Membrane removal — non-negotiable:** The silvery membrane (periosteum) on the bone-side of spare ribs must be removed. It is tough, inedible, and blocks smoke penetration. Use a butter knife to loosen one corner, grip with a paper towel, and peel in one piece. St. Louis cut means the sternum bone, cartilage tips, and skirt flap have been removed, leaving a rectangular rack of uniform thickness — essential for even cooking. Apply dry rub to both sides and rest 2 hours minimum.
- 2 225°F for 3 hours, unwrapped:** Place ribs bone-side down. The bones act as a thermal shield — meat side faces up and receives direct smoke exposure. Cherry wood adds sweetness and deep mahogany colour to pork; post oak provides the foundational smoke flavour. Spritz with 50/50 apple cider vinegar and water every 60–75 minutes. The moisture from spritz keeps the bark surface pliable and helps smoke particulates adhere, building colour and flavour.
- 3 The 3-2-1 decision (spare ribs):** After 3 hours, assess: if bark is set (dark, slightly firm to touch) and ribs are showing a ¼-inch bone pullback, you can wrap in butcher paper with a splash of apple juice for the remaining 2 hours (accelerates tenderness). For maximum bark, go *unwrapped* the full 5 hours at 225°F. Target internal temp: **195–203°F / 90–95°C** — or test using the **bend test**: pick up the rack with tongs at the mid-point; if it bends 90° and the bark cracks slightly, it is done.
- 4 Rest 20 minutes, slice and serve:** Rest wrapped in butcher paper 20 minutes. Slice between bones to separate. Per 5-bone half rack: each bone should have a clean pull — meat detaches with slight resistance (not falling off the bone, which means overcooked and mushy). BBQ sauce on the side. Great ribs do not need sauce — but the option validates the guest's preference. Plate on butcher paper with coleslaw and pickles.

**Chef's Tip:** St. Louis ribs vs baby backs: St. Louis has more fat, more cartilage, and more flavour. They take longer (5 hours vs 4) but produce a richer, more complex eating experience. Baby backs are leaner and more delicate. For a BBQ joint, St. Louis is the professional's choice for standalone rib orders. Know the difference and explain it when guests ask.

MUSTARD (rub) CELERY (rub) SOY (BBQ sauce may contain)

## Baby Back Ribs — Half Rack

6–7 bone half rack, loin back ribs, lighter smoke profile, tender pull · Sell: \$26.99

4 hrs smoke + 5 min plate Main Target FC: 28%

#### INGREDIENTS (HALF RACK / 6–7 BONES)

| INGREDIENT                            | WEIGHT    | COST          |
|---------------------------------------|-----------|---------------|
| Baby back ribs (loin back, half rack) | ~600g     | \$7.67        |
| House dry rub                         | 22g       | \$0.16        |
| Apple/cherry wood chips               | 300g fuel | \$0.26        |
| Apple juice (wrap/spritz)             | 60ml      | \$0.08        |
| House BBQ sauce (side)                | 40ml      | \$0.18        |
| <b>Total cost per serve</b>           |           | <b>\$8.35</b> |

|                |         |
|----------------|---------|
| Cost per serve | \$8.35  |
| Sell price     | \$26.99 |
| Food cost %    | 30.9%   |

Contribution margin

\$18.64

METHOD

- 1

**Baby backs anatomy:** Baby back ribs (loin back ribs) come from the upper portion of the rib cage, near the spine and loin. They are shorter, leaner, and more tender than spare ribs — which is why they cook faster (4 hours vs 5). The loin meat attached above the rib gives them a distinctive meaty texture. Remove membrane as with spare ribs. Apply rub and rest 2 hours.
- 2

**225°F with apple and cherry wood:** Lighter woods suit baby backs — their leaner, more delicate meat can be overpowered by heavy hickory. Apple wood produces a sweet, fruity smoke; cherry adds colour (mahogany) and mild sweetness. Spritz with apple juice every hour. At hour 2, assess moisture — if surface looks dry, increase spritz frequency. The leaner meat on baby backs has less internal fat to baste itself, unlike spare ribs.
- 3

**2-2 method for baby backs:** 2 hours unwrapped, then wrap in butcher paper with 2 tbsp apple juice for the final 2 hours. Baby backs benefit more from wrapping than spare ribs because of their lower fat content. The wrap creates a humid environment that prevents the leaner meat from drying. Target internal: **195–200°F / 90–93°C**. Bend test applies here too — ribs should flex and surface bark should crack.
- 4

**Rest and slice:** Rest 15–20 minutes, same as spare ribs. Baby backs slice more easily between bones due to shorter rib length. Presentation: fan the cut ribs slightly to show the smoke ring cross-section — this is a visual selling point. The smoke ring on baby backs is typically thinner than on spare ribs (less myoglobin in leaner pork) but should be visible and even. Garnish with pickled red onion for colour contrast.

**Chef's Tip:** Baby backs are often what guests mean when they say "ribs" — they are the most commonly served rib cut in American casual dining. Use this familiarity: they are your accessible rib option. The spare ribs are for guests who want more flavour and are comfortable with fattier meat. Train servers to explain this difference — it helps guests choose correctly and increases satisfaction.

MUSTARD (rub) CELERY (rub)

Pulled Pork Sandwich

8-hour smoked pork shoulder, house slaw, brioche bun, Carolina-style vinegar sauce · Sell: \$16.99

8 hrs smoke + 5 min plate Main Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS (PER SANDWICH)

| INGREDIENT                                   | WEIGHT      | COST   |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------|--------|
| Pork shoulder (Boston butt, bone-in), smoked | 170g pulled | \$2.12 |
| House dry rub (applied before smoke)         | 15g         | \$0.11 |
| Brioche bun (toasted)                        | 1 × 85g     | \$0.45 |
| House coleslaw                               | 60g         | \$0.04 |
| Carolina vinegar sauce (house batch)         | 30ml        | \$0.08 |
| Dill pickle slices (house or commercial)     | 15g         | \$0.04 |
| Total cost per serve                         |             | \$2.84 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$2.84  |
| Sell price          | \$16.99 |
| Food cost %         | 16.7%   |
| Contribution margin | \$14.15 |

METHOD

- 1

**Pork shoulder anatomy and yield:** A bone-in Boston butt (4–5kg) yields approximately 55–60% cooked weight after an 8-hour smoke — so a 5kg raw butt yields ~2.8kg of pulled pork (17–18 sandwich portions per butt). The bone-in cook is preferable: the bone conducts heat differently, and meat near the bone develops more flavour. Apply rub the night before. Pork shoulder has

enough intramuscular fat to self-baste — no need for injection.

- 2 Smoke at 225-250°F with hickory and oak, 8 hours:** Hickory is the traditional choice for pork shoulder — heavier, more assertive smoke that pairs well with the fattiness of the shoulder. Mix with oak for balance. Pork shoulder does not go through as dramatic a stall as brisket, but does hit 160-165°F and may plateau. Wrap in foil (not butcher paper — foil is appropriate here as we want the bark to soften into the braise rather than stay crunchy) with ¼ cup apple juice at hour 5. Target final internal: **203-205°F / 95-96°C**.

- 3 Pull technique:** Rest 30 minutes minimum after removing from smoker. Pull using two forks or bear-claw shredding tools while still warm — cold pulled pork is nearly impossible to shred. Work through the muscle groups, discarding pure fat pieces and any bone fragments. Toss pulled pork with a splash of Carolina vinegar sauce immediately — this adds moisture and flavour while the meat absorbs it. The pulled pork should be visibly smoky, moist, and have visible bark pieces integrated into the shred.

- 4 Build the sandwich:** Toast brioche bun cut-side on flat-top until golden. Bottom bun: layer of coleslaw (acts as moisture barrier, prevents bun sogginess). Load 170g pulled pork. Top with a tablespoon of Carolina vinegar sauce and dill pickle slices. Carolina sauce (apple cider vinegar + red pepper flakes + black pepper + sugar + salt) cuts through pork fat beautifully — do not substitute with sweet Kansas City sauce here. It is the wrong flavour profile for pulled pork.

**Chef's Tip:** Pulled pork is your highest-margin protein because pork shoulder is the cheapest cut (\$4/lb) and the smoke transforms it dramatically. It also holds exceptionally well — properly pulled pork in a covered hotel pan at 140°F maintains quality for 3-4 hours. Batch-smoke 2-3 butts on non-peak days for weekends. Pulled pork is one of the few BBQ items that actually improves 24 hours after smoking.

GLUTEN (brioche bun)

EGGS (brioche)

DAIRY (brioche)

## Smoked Chicken — Half Bird

Spatchcocked half chicken, dry-brined 24 hours, smoked 3 hours, finished on grill · Sell: \$21.99

3 hrs smoke + 5 min plate

Main

Target FC: 20%

### INGREDIENTS (HALF BIRD SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                                       | WEIGHT    | COST          |
|--------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------|
| Chicken half (breast + thigh + drumstick + wing) | ~550g     | \$3.40        |
| Dry brine (kosher salt, garlic powder, paprika)  | 12g       | \$0.06        |
| House dry rub (applied day-of)                   | 15g       | \$0.11        |
| Apple/cherry wood (smoke)                        | 250g fuel | \$0.22        |
| Compound butter (herb)                           | 15g       | \$0.14        |
| <b>Total cost per serve</b>                      |           | <b>\$3.93</b> |

|                            |                |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$3.93         |
| Sell price                 | \$21.99        |
| Food cost %                | 17.9%          |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$18.06</b> |

### METHOD

- 1 Dry brine 24 hours uncovered:** Halve whole chickens through the backbone and breastbone. Apply kosher salt (1 tsp per 450g) and garlic powder to all surfaces, including under skin where possible. Refrigerate uncovered on a wire rack for 24 hours. The dry brine draws moisture out, which reabsorbs carrying the salt deep into the muscle (superior penetration vs wet brine). The uncovered rest dries the skin surface — critical for crispy skin in a smoker environment.
- 2 Apply rub, smoke at 250°F with fruit wood:** Apply dry rub to exterior (not under skin — already salted). Smoke at 250°F (slightly higher than beef — chicken benefits from faster cooking and the higher temp helps render fat faster). Apple and cherry wood only — heavy smoke overwhelms chicken. After 90 minutes, breast should be at **145°F / 63°C** internal; continue until

breast reaches **160°F / 71°C** and thigh/drumstick reaches **175°F / 79°C** (thigh needs higher temp for textural perfection).

**3 Grill finish for skin:** Same principle as smoked wings. After reaching target internal temps in the smoker, transfer to a 500°F grill for 3–4 minutes, skin side down. This renders the subcutaneous fat and crisps the skin with radiant heat the smoker cannot produce. Watch carefully — the rub's brown sugar can burn quickly at this temperature. Move to cooler part of grill if flare-ups occur.

**4 Rest 5 minutes, plate with compound butter:** Rest briefly (5 min — chicken does not need as long as beef). Serve with a knob of herb compound butter (softened butter + fresh thyme + parsley + garlic + lemon zest) placed on the hot chicken to melt. The butter bastes the meat as it melts at the table. Serve with coleslaw, baked beans, and cornbread for the full plate experience.

**Chef's Tip:** The two-temperature problem in chicken (breast vs thigh) is solved by correct anatomical preparation. At the point where the breast reads 160°F, the thigh should read 175°F if you started with a correctly oriented half-bird. If your thigh is 175°F but breast is only 150°F, the bird was not positioned correctly in the smoker — the thigh (facing heat source) cooked faster. Adjust placement so breast faces indirect and thigh faces the heat source.

DAIRY (compound butter)

MUSTARD (rub)

# Beef Short Rib — Single Bone, 400g

USDA Choice plate short rib, 8-hour smoke, SPG rub, epic bark formation · Sell: \$34.99

8-10 hrs smoke + 5 min plate

Premium Main

Target FC: 29%

## INGREDIENTS (SINGLE BONE / 400G)

| INGREDIENT                                 | WEIGHT                  | COST           |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------|----------------|
| Beef plate short rib (bone-in, single rib) | ~800g raw → 400g served | \$14.11        |
| SPG rub (coarse salt + pepper + garlic)    | 20g                     | \$0.10         |
| Post oak wood chunks                       | 500g fuel               | \$0.44         |
| Horseradish cream (side)                   | 30ml                    | \$0.22         |
| <b>Total cost per serve</b>                |                         | <b>\$14.87</b> |

|                            |                |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$14.87        |
| Sell price                 | \$34.99        |
| Food cost %                | 42.5%          |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$20.12</b> |

## METHOD

**1 Understanding the cut — plate vs chuck:** Plate short ribs (USDA 123 cut, bone-in) are what you want. These are thick-cut single bones (3–4 inch meat cap above the bone) with extreme intramuscular fat. Chuck short ribs are smaller and work for braising but not for true low-and-slow BBQ. Plate short ribs are sometimes called "dinosaur ribs" due to their prehistoric appearance. Trim hard fat cap but leave the fat seam intact — it will render during the smoke. Apply generous SPG rub night before.

**2 225°F smoke, post oak only, 8-10 hours:** Short ribs have extremely high collagen and fat content — they need the full time. Use only post oak — the flavour profile should be clean and beefy, not complicated by multiple wood types. Place bone-side down. The bone will heat more slowly than the meat, creating a natural differential that protects the bottom while the top receives maximum smoke exposure. Expect a significant stall at 160–170°F (same as brisket) that may last 3 hours.

**3 No wrap protocol — bark is the product:** Short ribs can and should be cooked unwrapped the entire time. Unlike brisket (which has a large flat section prone to drying), the short rib meat cap is small, well-marbled, and self-bastes from rendered fat. Wrapping would compromise the spectacular bark that forms on the exterior — which is the visual and textural selling point of this dish. Target internal: **203-205°F / 95-96°C**. Probe slide test applies.

**4 Rest 30-45 minutes, present whole:** Rest wrapped in butcher paper 30–45 minutes. Present

the whole bone-in rib to the table on a board — do not slice it in the kitchen. The dramatic size and appearance of a 400g beef short rib is a tableside theatre moment. Provide a sharp knife and fork. Horseradish cream on the side — the cool heat of horseradish cuts through the extreme richness of the beef fat. This dish will generate social media content without asking.

**Chef's Tip:** Beef short ribs are your prestige item — the highest cost, highest drama plate on the menu. At 42% food cost they look inefficient, but the \$20 contribution margin is strong and the halo effect on table perception is worth it. One table with a short rib draws the attention of surrounding tables. The visual sell is free marketing. Price it accordingly, feature it in photography, and make it unavailable once sold out — scarcity drives desirability.

DAIRY (horseradish cream)

## Hot Link Sausage Plate

Two house-style hot links, smoked 1.5 hours, served with mustard, pickles, and onions · Sell: \$17.99

90 min smoke + 3 min plate   Main   Target FC: 24%

### INGREDIENTS (2-LINK SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                                                | WEIGHT         | COST   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|----------------|--------|
| Hot link sausage (beef + pork, fresh or supplier-sourced) | 2 × 120g links | \$2.94 |
| Yellow mustard + grain mustard (serve)                    | 20ml each      | \$0.08 |
| Pickled white onion (house)                               | 30g            | \$0.06 |
| Dill pickles (sliced)                                     | 20g            | \$0.05 |
| White bread (Texas tradition)                             | 2 slices       | \$0.12 |
| Total cost per serve                                      |                | \$3.25 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$3.25  |
| Sell price          | \$17.99 |
| Food cost %         | 18.1%   |
| Contribution margin | \$14.74 |

### METHOD

- Sausage sourcing strategy:** Source pre-made hot links from a regional Texas-style sausage maker, or if volume justifies, produce in-house using a coarse-ground beef and pork blend (70/30), seasoned with cayenne, black pepper, garlic, coriander, and crushed red pepper. The hot link should have a coarse grind, natural casing (sheep or hog), and visible spice flecks. Avoid commercial fine-ground frank-style links — they lack the texture and flavour profile appropriate to a BBQ environment.
- Cold sausage into a cold smoker — the snap technique:** Place sausages in smoker before bringing to temperature. Cold sausage entering a cold smoker allows smoke to penetrate the casing before it sets, producing better smoke flavour. Bring smoker to 250°F with the sausages inside. After 60–90 minutes, internal temp should reach **160°F / 71°C**. The casing should be deep red-brown with visible smoke staining and should "snap" when pierced with a knife.
- The sausage snap test:** A properly smoked and cooked sausage link will audibly snap when you bite through the casing. This snap is caused by: (1) the natural casing drying slightly in the smoke, (2) the fat inside rendering and creating internal pressure. If the sausage peels rather than snaps, the casing has been steamed (too much moisture) rather than smoke-dried. Serve immediately from the smoker — the snap deteriorates within 20 minutes of removal.
- Texas tray presentation:** Slice one link on a bias to show the interior cross-section (visible smoke penetration, coarse grind, fat specs). Leave the second link whole for the guest to experience the snap. Serve on butcher paper with sliced white bread (the bread is functional — guests use it to soak up rendered fat and juices), yellow mustard, grain mustard, pickled white onion, and dill pickles. This is the purest, most historically authentic BBQ plate you serve.

**Chef's Tip:** At Texas BBQ joints, sausage is ordered by the ring (whole link). If you develop relationships with local Texas-style sausage makers, feature them by name on the menu —

provenance sells. "Schmidt Family Sausage, Elgin Texas style" is more compelling than "house hot link." Provenance storytelling is one of the most cost-effective marketing tools in BBQ.

GLUTEN (white bread)

MUSTARD

## BBQ Brisket Platter

Sliced brisket (150g) + choice of 2 sides + jalapeño cheddar cornbread · Sell: \$29.99

5 min plate

Platter

Target FC: 26%

### INGREDIENTS (PER PLATTER)

| COMPONENT                               | PORTION  | COST   |
|-----------------------------------------|----------|--------|
| Texas brisket (sliced flat + point mix) | 150g     | \$3.22 |
| Side 1 (coleslaw or baked beans)        | 100g     | \$0.45 |
| Side 2 (coleslaw or baked beans)        | 100g     | \$0.45 |
| Jalapeño cheddar cornbread              | 1 piece  | \$0.36 |
| Pickles + jalapeños                     | 30g      | \$0.08 |
| White bread (2 slices)                  | 2 slices | \$0.12 |
| Total cost per platter                  |          | \$4.68 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$4.68  |
| Sell price          | \$29.99 |
| Food cost %         | 15.6%   |
| Contribution margin | \$25.31 |

### METHOD

- The platter is your anchor item:** At \$29.99 with a 15.6% food cost, this is your most profitable single plate. It bundles your highest-profile protein (brisket) with high-margin sides into a complete experience. Train servers to default-suggest the platter to any guest ordering brisket à la carte — the upsell from \$26.99 (brisket alone) to \$29.99 (platter) adds significant value perception for only \$3 more.
- Brisket mix for platters:** For platters, serve a mix of flat (lean slices) and point (fattier, more marbled). This gives the guest contrast — the flat showcases the smoke ring and clean beefy flavour; the point delivers the rich, melt-in-mouth experience. 150g = approximately 4–5 slices depending on thickness. Slice to order from rested brisket. If the brisket has cooled, lay slices flat on a hot flat-top for 30 seconds each side — do not microwave.
- Side composition for balance:** The classic platter pairing is coleslaw (acid, crunch) + baked beans (sweet, rich). The contrast is deliberate — you want opposing textural and flavour profiles alongside brisket. If a guest requests two of the same side, accommodate, but the server should gently suggest the contrast: "Most guests love the coleslaw alongside the beans — it cuts through the richness really nicely."
- Butcher paper plating:** Line a metal tray or wooden board with unbleached butcher paper. Lay the brisket slices slightly fanned to show the smoke ring. Cornbread wedge at one corner. Sides in 3oz ramekins or directly on the paper (for the Texas tray aesthetic). Pickles and jalapeños tucked alongside. White bread folded once. The visual should communicate abundance, rusticity, and craft — not fine dining, not fast food.

**Chef's Tip:** The platter format encourages sharing and grazing — guests spend more time at the table, order more drinks, and have a more satisfying meal experience. High platter attachment rate (platter-to-brisket-alone ratio) is a key metric to track. A well-trained server can move that ratio from 50% to 75% with consistent suggestive selling language.

GLUTEN

DAIRY

EGGS

MUSTARD

# The Pitmaster — Full Rack Spare Ribs + Brisket + Sausage

Feeds 2. Full rack St. Louis ribs · 200g brisket · 2 hot links · 4 sides · Sell: \$79.99

10 min plate   Sharing Feast   Target FC: 30%

## INGREDIENTS (FOR 2 PEOPLE)

| COMPONENT                                   | PORTION  | COST           |
|---------------------------------------------|----------|----------------|
| St. Louis spare ribs (full rack, ~10 bones) | ~1,400g  | \$13.89        |
| Texas brisket (sliced, flat + point)        | 200g     | \$4.29         |
| Hot link sausage                            | 2 × 120g | \$2.94         |
| Coleslaw                                    | 2 × 100g | \$0.26         |
| Baked beans                                 | 2 × 130g | \$0.58         |
| Jalapeño cornbread                          | 2 pieces | \$0.72         |
| Pickles + jalapeños                         | 60g      | \$0.14         |
| House BBQ sauce (3 types)                   | 3 × 30ml | \$0.35         |
| <b>Total cost</b>                           |          | <b>\$23.17</b> |

|                            |                |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| Cost per board             | \$23.17        |
| Sell price                 | \$79.99        |
| Food cost %                | 29.0%          |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$56.82</b> |

## METHOD

- 1 Coordination — the 3-protein challenge:** The Pitmaster requires three proteins that each have different cook times: ribs (5 hours), brisket (12 hours), sausage (90 min). The smoker timing is what makes this achievable: brisket starts at 5am, ribs go in at 6am, sausage goes in at 9am. All are done by 11am for lunch service. The Pitmaster is served from pre-smoked proteins held at **140°F / 60°C** — it is an assembly plate, not a to-order cook.
- 2 Portion integrity:** Full rack ribs means 10–11 bones, not half. Guests ordering The Pitmaster expect maximum abundance — do not under-portion. The brisket 200g should be a generous fan of slices from both flat and point. The sausages should be whole links, one sliced on bias as presentation, one whole. This is a showstopper plate — every element should look massive and intentional on the board.
- 3 The three-sauce presentation:** BBQ sauce philosophy at the table requires three options: (1) Texas-style (thin, tomato-vinegar, mildly sweet), (2) Kansas City-style (thick, sweet, tomato-molasses), (3) Carolina Gold (mustard-based, vinegar-forward). Each sauce pairs differently with each protein. Server script for the Pitmaster should explain this pairing: "Texas sauce with the brisket, Kansas City with the ribs, Carolina Gold with the sausage — though rules are made to be broken."
- 4 Board construction and table impact:** Use the largest board in the house. Layer from back to front: ribs rack standing slightly upright (propped on cornbread wedge for height), brisket fanned on one side, sausage on the other. Sides in separate ramekins alongside. Three sauce pots at the front. Pickles scattered. This plate should be visible from across the room when it walks out. Train staff to carry it above shoulder height briefly when approaching the table — the theatre of arrival is part of the experience.

**Chef's Tip:** The Pitmaster is your best social media asset and your best driver of neighbouring table curiosity. Every time one goes out, at least one adjacent table asks "What is that?" Track Pitmaster sales as a % of total covers — a well-marketed BBQ restaurant should sell The Pitmaster to 15–20% of all dining groups of 2. Any server who sells 3 Pitmasters in a shift should be recognised explicitly.

GLUTEN   DAIRY   EGGS   MUSTARD   CELERY

# Smoked Turkey Breast — Sliced, 180g

Bone-in turkey breast half, brined 12 hours, smoked 4 hours, sliced thin · Sell: \$20.99

4 hrs smoke + 5 min plate   Main   Target FC: 18%

## INGREDIENTS (180G SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                               | WEIGHT         | COST   |
|------------------------------------------|----------------|--------|
| Turkey breast half (bone-in, ~2kg)       | 180g served    | \$2.76 |
| Brine (salt, sugar, apple juice, spices) | per batch      | \$0.22 |
| Herb butter (under skin)                 | 30g per breast | \$0.18 |
| House dry rub (light application)        | 10g            | \$0.07 |
| Apple/pecan wood                         | 250g fuel      | \$0.22 |
| Total cost per serve                     |                | \$3.45 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$3.45  |
| Sell price          | \$20.99 |
| Food cost %         | 16.4%   |
| Contribution margin | \$17.54 |

## METHOD

- 1 Brine 12 hours — non-negotiable for turkey:** Turkey breast is extremely lean and will dry out without brining. Wet brine (1 gallon water, ¾ cup kosher salt, ¼ cup brown sugar, 2 cups apple juice, bay leaves, peppercorns, garlic) for 12 hours refrigerated. The brine raises the water content of the breast meat — even if some moisture is lost during smoking, the starting moisture level is high enough to result in a juicy final product. No other technique compensates for skipping the brine on turkey breast.
- 2 Herb butter under skin + dry rub on top:** After brining, pat completely dry. Separate the skin from the breast meat with your fingers and push room-temperature herb butter (butter + fresh sage + thyme + rosemary + garlic) under the skin in an even layer. This basts the meat from underneath during smoking where the skin can't capture direct smoke. Apply a light dry rub on the skin exterior. The dual-layer flavour application produces complex, layered taste.
- 3 225°F with pecan and apple wood, 4 hours:** Pecan wood is ideal for turkey — it produces a mild, nutty smoke that complements poultry without overpowering it. Place breast skin-side up throughout the entire cook. Target skin temp: reaching **165°F / 74°C** internal in the thickest part of the breast. Do not exceed 165°F on turkey breast — unlike poultry thighs, breast meat becomes dry and chalky if overcooked even slightly. Monitor carefully in the final hour.
- 4 Rest 20 minutes, slice thin:** Rest 20 minutes before slicing. Slice very thin (⅛ inch) on a meat slicer or with a sharp carving knife, across the grain. Turkey breast smoked correctly has a visible smoke ring and moist, compact texture. Fan slices to show cross-section. Serve with gravy (optional) or house mustard + pickles. Turkey is your BBQ menu's option for guests avoiding pork or seeking lower-fat protein — feature it explicitly in allergy/preference conversations.

**Chef's Tip:** Smoked turkey breast is significantly undervalued in American BBQ culture. It is cheaper than brisket, has a 16% food cost, and appeals to health-conscious guests who still want the BBQ experience. The challenge is execution — dry turkey is a reputation killer. Invest time in the brine process and you will produce turkey that surprises guests expecting dry, dull white meat.

DAIRY (herb butter)   MUSTARD (rub may contain)

## 3 Desserts

### Banana Pudding

Southern-style vanilla pudding, fresh banana, Nilla wafers, whipped cream · Sell: \$8.99

3 min plate   Dessert   Target FC: 12%



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE / BATCH OF 12)

| INGREDIENT                                                          | WEIGHT          | COST   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|--------|
| Fresh bananas, sliced                                               | 80g per serve   | \$0.06 |
| House vanilla pudding (milk, egg yolks, sugar, cornstarch, vanilla) | 150ml per serve | \$0.32 |
| Nilla wafers (vanilla wafer cookies)                                | 30g per serve   | \$0.18 |
| Fresh whipped cream                                                 | 40ml per serve  | \$0.14 |
| Vanilla extract                                                     | per batch       | \$0.03 |
| Total cost per serve                                                |                 | \$0.73 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$0.73 |
| Sell price          | \$8.99 |
| Food cost %         | 8.1%   |
| Contribution margin | \$8.26 |

METHOD

- 1

**Pastry cream base (house-made, not instant):** Whisk egg yolks and sugar until pale; whisk in cornstarch. Heat milk to steaming, temper into yolk mixture, return to heat, stir constantly until thick (large bubbles appear at surface). Add vanilla extract and a knob of butter off heat for glossiness and richness. Transfer to a shallow pan, press plastic wrap directly to surface to prevent skin formation. Chill completely. This custard is the product — instant pudding produces inferior flavour and a gummy texture that experienced diners notice immediately.
- 2

**Layer construction in mason jars:** Use wide-mouth mason jars (8oz) for individual serves — the rustic presentation fits the BBQ aesthetic. Layer: custard → wafers → banana slices → custard → wafers → banana. Allow jars to rest refrigerated 2–4 hours minimum after assembly. This rest is critical: the wafers absorb moisture from the custard and soften into a cake-like layer. Fresh-assembled banana pudding (crunchy wafers) is amateur; properly rested pudding (pillowy wafers throughout) is professional.
- 3

**Banana browning management:** Slice bananas fresh for each batch. To prevent browning, toss banana slices in a small amount of lemon juice (just enough to coat — too much makes it sour). Alternatively, use very ripe but firm bananas and batch only enough for the next 4-hour service period. Browned bananas in banana pudding are a quality failure that erodes trust in house-made quality.
- 4

**Service:** Top cold jar with freshly whipped cream (not canned — the texture and flavour difference is significant). Add 2–3 whole Nilla wafers standing upright as garnish. Serve on a small wooden board with a long dessert spoon. Temperature: straight from refrigerator — cold banana pudding is correct. Room-temperature pudding is unpleasant. This dessert pre-sells itself: see Service Training section for the Banana Pudding Pre-Sell script.

**Chef's Tip:** Banana pudding is your dessert anchor — nostalgic, Southern, and impossible to replicate at home at this quality level. It is also your cheapest dessert with the highest margin. Pre-sell it at the beginning of the meal ("I'll let you know right now — we make banana pudding in-house and we run out most days..."). That scarcity cue drives orders. Batch daily, track sell-out time, and aim to sell out by 8pm every night.

DAIRY EGGS GLUTEN (wafers)

Peach Cobbler

Fresh Georgia peaches, brown sugar biscuit crust, served warm with vanilla ice cream · Sell: \$9.99

5 min plate Dessert Target FC: 15%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE / BATCH OF 10)

| INGREDIENT                                | WEIGHT         | COST   |
|-------------------------------------------|----------------|--------|
| Fresh peaches (or frozen, thawed), sliced | 180g per serve | \$0.80 |

|                                   |                |        |
|-----------------------------------|----------------|--------|
| Brown sugar (filling + crust)     | 40g per serve  | \$0.07 |
| All-purpose flour (biscuit crust) | 50g per serve  | \$0.03 |
| Butter (crust + filling)          | 25g per serve  | \$0.14 |
| Buttermilk (biscuit)              | 40ml per serve | \$0.06 |
| Cinnamon, nutmeg, vanilla         | per batch      | \$0.04 |
| Vanilla ice cream (2 scoops)      | 100g           | \$0.35 |
| Total cost per serve              |                | \$1.49 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$1.49 |
| Sell price          | \$9.99 |
| Food cost %         | 14.9%  |
| Contribution margin | \$8.50 |

METHOD

- 1

**Peach filling — macerate first:** Peel and slice peaches into ½-inch wedges. Toss with brown sugar, cinnamon, a pinch of nutmeg, and a teaspoon of cornstarch per batch. Macerate 30 minutes — the sugar draws juice from the peaches, creating a natural sauce. Do not add extra liquid — the macerated juice is the sauce. If using frozen peaches, thaw completely and drain excess liquid before using (frozen peaches release significantly more water).
- 2

**Biscuit crust — drop style, not rolled:** Combine flour, baking powder, brown sugar, salt with cold cubed butter (cut in until pea-sized pieces remain). Add cold buttermilk. Mix until just combined — lumpy and rough, not smooth. Drop spoonfuls over the peach filling rather than rolling and cutting. Drop biscuits produce a more rustic, craggy texture with more surface area for browning. This is intentional — the rough exterior browns deeply and creates textural contrast with the soft filling below.
- 3

**Batch bake at 375°F, portion and reheat to order:** Bake assembled cobbler (in a 9×13 hotel pan or large cast iron) at 375°F / 190°C for 40–45 minutes until biscuit top is deep golden and filling is bubbling at edges. Cool slightly, cut into 10 individual portions. Refrigerate. For service: individual portion in a cast iron mini skillet, 375°F oven 8 minutes to reheat through, or microwave 90 seconds + 2 minutes broiler for surface colour. Internal temperature should reach **165°F / 74°C**.
- 4

**Serve hot with cold ice cream:** The temperature contrast (hot cobbler + cold ice cream) is the defining sensory experience. The ice cream should begin melting as soon as it hits the hot cobbler — this is correct. The melting ice cream integrates with the cobbler juice to create a rich, creamy sauce. Serve in a pre-warmed bowl or skillet to extend the hot-cold contrast window. 2 scoops vanilla ice cream, a light dusting of cinnamon, and a fresh mint sprig for colour.

**Chef's Tip:** Source peaches in season (June–September) and freeze at peak ripeness for year-round use. The quality of your peaches determines the quality of your cobbler. Supermarket off-season peaches are usually picked underripe and lack the sugar development of tree-ripened fruit. If using off-season commercial peaches, increase the brown sugar in the filling slightly and add a splash of peach nectar.

DAIRY   GLUTEN   EGGS (ice cream)

Pecan Pie Slice

Texas-style pecan pie, butter crust, dark corn syrup, toasted pecans · Sell: \$7.99

3 min plate   Dessert   Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS (WHOLE PIE / 8 SLICES)

| INGREDIENT                | WEIGHT     | COST   |
|---------------------------|------------|--------|
| Whole pecans (toasted)    | 250g       | \$6.68 |
| Dark corn syrup           | 240ml      | \$0.55 |
| Brown sugar + white sugar | 100g + 50g | \$0.22 |

|                                |                     |                 |
|--------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|
| Eggs                           | 3 × 55g             | \$1.05          |
| Unsalted butter (melted)       | 60g                 | \$0.33          |
| Vanilla extract, pinch of salt | misc                | \$0.08          |
| Butter pie crust (house-made)  | 1 blind-baked shell | \$0.55          |
| Pie cost · Per slice (÷8)      |                     | \$9.46 · \$1.18 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per slice      | \$1.18 |
| Sell price          | \$7.99 |
| Food cost %         | 14.8%  |
| Contribution margin | \$6.81 |

METHOD

- 1

**Toast pecans first:** Spread whole pecans on a baking sheet and toast at 350°F for 8-10 minutes until fragrant and slightly darkened. Toasting deepens the nuttiness and removes bitterness from raw pecans — untoasted pecan pie has a flat, one-dimensional flavour. Let cool completely before using. Toasted pecans also float more evenly in the filling, creating the classic layered appearance.
- 2

**Filling — the gel set:** Whisk eggs, corn syrup (dark is critical — light corn syrup produces a paler, less complex filling), brown sugar, white sugar, melted butter, vanilla, and salt. The eggs are what set the filling — they form a soft custard gel around the pecans. Do not over-whisk (incorporates too much air, creates a bubbly set). Partially baked (blind-baked) crust prevents a soggy bottom. Pour filling into warm crust, arrange pecans on top.
- 3

**Bake at 325°F / 163°C for 50-60 minutes:** Low temperature prevents the eggs from curdling and the filling from puffing and cracking. The pie is done when the edges are set but the centre still has a slight wobble (it will set further as it cools). Internal temp of the filling: **200°F / 93°C**. The surface should be deep mahogany and the pecans should be glossy. A cracked top means overbaked.
- 4

**Cool completely before slicing — minimum 4 hours:** Pecan pie must be completely cooled (room temp or refrigerator) before slicing. Hot pecan pie is liquid inside and will not hold its shape. A properly cooled slice should stand upright without drooping. Serve at room temperature with a side of vanilla ice cream or lightly sweetened whipped cream. A sprinkle of flaky sea salt on the slice elevates the flavour complexity dramatically.

**Chef's Tip:** Pecan pie is your most expensive dessert to produce due to pecan prices (\$12/lb wholesale). Control costs by using a pecan-to-filling ratio that keeps the top layer visually generous while the filling carries the bulk of the set. Broken pecan pieces in the filling are fine (and often preferred for eating). Save whole pecans for the visible top layer only.

DAIRY EGGS GLUTEN (crust) TREE NUTS (pecans)

Smoked Chocolate Brownie

Fudgy brownie finished in the smoker, vanilla ice cream, caramel drizzle · Sell: \$8.99

5 min plate Dessert Target FC: 12%

INGREDIENTS (BATCH 9×9 / 9 SERVES)

| INGREDIENT                            | WEIGHT     | COST   |
|---------------------------------------|------------|--------|
| Dark chocolate (70%), chopped         | 200g       | \$1.40 |
| Unsalted butter                       | 150g       | \$0.82 |
| White + brown sugar                   | 200g + 50g | \$0.38 |
| Eggs (large)                          | 3 × 55g    | \$1.05 |
| All-purpose flour                     | 80g        | \$0.05 |
| Cocoa powder, vanilla, salt           | misc       | \$0.18 |
| Vanilla ice cream (1 scoop per serve) | 60g        | \$0.21 |

House caramel sauce

20ml

\$0.08

Batch cost · Per serve (÷9)

\$8.77 · \$0.97

|                            |               |
|----------------------------|---------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$0.97        |
| Sell price                 | \$8.99        |
| Food cost %                | 10.8%         |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$8.02</b> |

#### METHOD

- 1 Brownie base — fudgy formula:** Melt chocolate and butter together (double boiler or microwave in 30-second bursts). Whisk in sugars, then eggs one at a time. The egg incorporation is critical: add eggs to the slightly cooled chocolate mixture (not hot) and whisk vigorously — this creates the characteristic "shiny top" on brownies by dissolving the sugar layer at the surface. Fold in flour minimally — just until combined. Over-mixing develops gluten and produces cakey brownies. The goal is dense, fudgy squares.
- 2 Oven bake first — 325°F for 25 minutes:** Pour batter into parchment-lined 9x9 pan. Bake at 325°F / 163°C for 22-25 minutes. The brownie should be just set — a toothpick at centre should come out with moist crumbs (not raw batter, not clean). Underbaked slightly is correct. Cool completely, refrigerate 2 hours (fudgy brownies cut cleanly only when cold), then cut into 9 squares.
- 3 The smoke finish — 10 minutes in live smoker:** This is the signature technique. For service, place a cold brownie square on a wire rack and put it in the smoker at 250°F for exactly 10 minutes with a fresh piece of apple or cherry wood. The cold brownie absorbs a light, sweet smoke note in the surface layer. 10 minutes is the window — longer and the brownie becomes bitter. The result is a brownie that smells like the smokehouse but tastes like the best chocolate brownie you have ever eaten.
- 4 Plate immediately after smoking:** Remove from smoker, plate while warm. One scoop vanilla ice cream directly on the hot brownie, house caramel drizzle over both. The ice cream melts slightly at the edges — present immediately. This dessert will not hold after plating. Train servers that smoked brownies are a 2-minute window from smoker to table. The theatrical smoke aroma as the plate arrives is part of the experience — it is detectable from adjacent tables.

**Chef's Tip:** The "smoked brownie" technique is your most unique menu innovation — no other dessert item simultaneously delivers the BBQ identity and a world-class chocolate dessert. Feature it in your social media photography. The visual of smoke curling off a brownie with melting ice cream photographs extraordinarily well. Make it a house signature and protect the technique.

DAIRY

EGGS

GLUTEN

SOY (dark chocolate may contain)

## 4 Drinks

### House Sweet Tea

\$3.99

Black tea brewed strong, chilled, sweetened while hot (not after) with cane sugar. Serve over ice with lemon wheel. The ratio: 2 family-size teabags per quart water, 3/4 cup sugar dissolved while hot. Sweet tea must be sweet enough to drink without stirring — Southern tradition demands it.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$0.22      |
| Sell price         | \$3.99      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>5.5%</b> |

NONE

### Arnold Palmer

\$4.49

Half sweet tea, half fresh-squeezed lemonade, poured simultaneously over ice from two pitchers. The visual separation is the presentation. Garnish with lemon wheel and fresh mint. The lemonade cuts the tannic

sweetness of the tea — this is your most refreshing non-alcoholic option against fatty BBQ. Fresh lemon juice only — not concentrate.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$0.48       |
| Sell price         | \$4.49       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>10.7%</b> |

NONE

### Lone Star / PBR

\$5.99

Served ice-cold in the bottle. These American lagers are the canonical BBQ pairing — light, effervescent, and designed not to compete with the smoke flavour. Stock both and let guests choose. The low IBU (bitterness) and clean finish refreshes the palate between bites of fatty, rich meats. No pint glass — Texas tradition is to drink these from the bottle.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per bottle)  | \$1.20       |
| Sell price         | \$5.99       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>20.0%</b> |

GLUTEN (barley)

### Bourbon Old Fashioned

\$13.99

2oz bourbon (well brand), 2 dashes Angostura bitters, ½ tsp demerara sugar syrup, large ice cube, expressed orange peel. The Old Fashioned is the BBQ cocktail — bourbon's vanilla-caramel notes parallel the smoke and char of the meat. Offer an optional *smoked glass* variant: torch rosemary in the glass before building. Cost using \$28/750ml bourbon: ~\$2.25/drink at well pricing.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$2.25       |
| Sell price         | \$13.99      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>16.1%</b> |

SULFITES (bitters)

### Fresh Lemonade

\$4.99

Hand-squeezed, simple syrup, cold water, ice. Batch the simple syrup. Squeeze lemons fresh each service period — pre-squeezed lemon juice past 4 hours develops an off-flavour from oxidation. For kids and non-drinkers this is your premium NA option. Serve in a 16oz mason jar with a paper straw for the visual. Offer flavoured variants: strawberry basil or jalapeño lemonade as seasonal features.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$0.58       |
| Sell price         | \$4.99       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>11.6%</b> |

NONE

### Dr Pepper

\$3.49

Texas institution. Serve over ice in a branded glass or mason jar — never in the can. Dr Pepper's 23-flavour complexity pairs surprisingly well with BBQ; the spiced, almost cherry-like sweetness complements the smoke and char. Stock in cans/fountain and decant. A detail guests notice: ice-cold soda in a cold glass vs a lukewarm can on the table. Temperature at service: **34-38°F / 1-3°C**.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per serving) | \$0.35       |
| Sell price         | \$3.49       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>10.0%</b> |

NONE

### Watermelon Agua Fresca

\$5.49

Blended fresh watermelon, lime juice, a pinch of sugar, cold water — strained. Batch 2 liters per service period. The natural sweetness and high water content makes this the most refreshing drink on your menu against the heat and salt of BBQ. Serve over crushed ice in a mason jar with a lime wheel and Tajín rim (optional for guests who want the heat). A surprisingly high-margin item with low cost and high perceived value.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$0.62       |
| Sell price         | \$5.49       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>11.3%</b> |

NONE

### Whisky & Coke

\$10.99

1.5oz well bourbon or Tennessee whiskey + Coca-Cola, tall glass, ice, lime wedge. Simple and popular. Position as the "Jack & Coke" alternative using your own label or a well bourbon at lower cost. Train servers to offer upsized to 2oz pour for \$2 more — a simple upsell with good uptake at BBQ tables. The sweet, caramel Coca-Cola base and whiskey vanilla note is the most accessible whiskey cocktail for non-spirit drinkers.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost (per glass)   | \$1.72       |
| Sell price         | \$10.99      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>15.6%</b> |

GLUTEN (some whiskeys)

## 5 Kitchen Prep Flow — 5am to 3pm

**Smoker-Centric Scheduling:** The BBQ kitchen revolves around the smoker. Every prep decision flows backward from the **11am opening**. The brisket requires 12+ hours — it must be rubbed the previous evening and be in the smoker by **5:00am sharp**. Ribs go in at 6am (5-hour cook). Pork shoulder at 6:30am (8-hour cook). Sausage and turkey go in at 9am (shorter cooks). This staggered start system means the Pitmaster arrives at 5am, not 7am like most restaurant kitchens. This is the core operational difference between a BBQ restaurant and any other restaurant format. Your Pitmaster's alarm is your most important operational KPI.

| Time Block                                   | Pitmaster                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Line Cook                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Steward                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>5:00am - 6:30am</b><br><b>FIRE START</b>  | Light smoker, load hardwood (post oak + hickory). Bring to 225°F. Load yesterday-rubbed brisket(s) fat-cap up. Confirm wireless thermometer probes inserted. Log start temp and time in smoke journal. Start second brisket if weekend. Check wood supply for full day — pre-split and stage next to smoker. Taste brisket rub on hand — adjust next batch if needed. | Arrive 6am. Receive morning produce delivery — inspect, weigh, sign off. Begin coleslaw batch 1: salt-wilt cabbage. Boil brine for pickled jalapeños (make 3x per week). Set up mise en place station: ramekins, tongs, knives, cutting board sections labeled. Portion frozen proteins needed for day. | Open building. Check temperature logs from overnight (walk-in must be ≤38°F). Sanitize all prep surfaces. Set up dishwash station. Receive and date all deliveries. Break down cardboard. Refill soap, paper towel dispensers throughout kitchen. |
| <b>6:30am - 8:30am</b><br><b>SMOKE BUILD</b> | Load spare rib racks (6am). Load pork shoulder(s) (6:30am). Monitor fire — add 2-3 wood chunks every 45 min. Target: steady thin blue smoke (not billowing white smoke, which indicates incomplete combustion and bitter off-                                                                                                                                         | Batch cornbread mix (dry ingredients pre-measured). Prepare baked beans batch: render brisket trimmings, sauté onion, garlic. Mix bean sauce. Get beans into low simmer (or                                                                                                                             | Polish glassware and flatware from previous night. Set up front-of-house: check condiment stations (sauce bottles filled, labels forward). Stock                                                                                                  |

|                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                         | flavour). Spritz brisket with ACV-water at 7:30am. Log internal temps every 30 min. Adjust vents to maintain 225–250°F range.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | smoker). Slice and salt banana pudding bananas (lemon juice), layer jars, refrigerate. Make pastry cream if low. Prep peach cobbler filling (macerate).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | server station: napkins, straws, menus, specials boards. Pre-fold napkins for all 48 covers. Set tables.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>8:30am - 10:00am<br/>PRODUCTION</b>  | Trim and portion today's turkey breast halves, apply brine-rub, load into smoker at 9:00am with pecan/apple wood. Load hot link sausages cold-start into smoker at 9:00am. Check brisket internal temp — if approaching 160°F stall, monitor closely. If timing requires, execute Texas Crutch wrap at 165°F. Check smoke color: should be thin, pale blue — add fresh wood if white smoke appears.                                               | Batch coleslaw dressing, combine with wilted cabbage, rest in cooler. Bake cornbread (425°F, 20 min), cool, cut, portion. Portion all dessert components: slice cobbler portions, label. Prep compound herb butters. Slice smoked chicken halves from previous batch (day-olds need 5am start tomorrow). Set up sauté line: butter, spices, sauces prepped.                                               | Deep clean reach-in refrigerator shelves. Check all date labels — discard anything past 3-day mark. Restock single-use supplies: butcher paper sheets cut to size, to-go containers, sauce cups. Run pre-service dishwasher cycle. Fill ice bins.                                                                                                                          |
| <b>10:00am - 11:00am<br/>FINAL PREP</b> | Confirm all proteins: brisket should be 185–195°F (approaching final stage), ribs at 175–185°F, pork shoulder at 185°F, sausage at 155°F. Determine if any items need to be pulled early (timing adjustments). Begin resting any briskets that hit 203°F early. Taste test brisket — if probe slides in like butter and bark is firm and dark, it's ready. Slice sample slice from flat end for quality check — smoke ring, moisture, tenderness. | Set up service line: all sides in hotel pans at <b>140°F</b> steam table. Pre-slice 10–15 servings of brisket for rapid service. Set up plating station: butcher paper sheets, tongs, sauce bottles. Brief on day's sold-out risk: if only 3 briskets today and 40 covers at lunch, flag to front-of-house that brisket may sell out by 2pm. Pre-sell Pitmaster platters for dinner reservations.         | Final floor sweep and mop front of house. Check bathroom supplies. Set up host station — menus, reservation list. Position outdoor signage. Confirm POS system running. Pre-authorise any advance credit tabs. Brief front-of-house team on specials, 86 list, Pitmaster availability count. Sound check for background music (classic country/blues).                     |
| <b>11:00am - 3:00pm<br/>SERVICE</b>     | Monitor smoke during service — do not neglect smoker during lunch rush. Smoke is continuous: tomorrow's brisket may be rubbed at noon for overnight rest. Pull ribs at 1pm (5-hour mark), rest in cooler. Load afternoon smoke batch (chicken at 11am, ready by 2pm for dinner). Coordinate with line cook on hold levels — communicate every 30 min: "Brisket: 8 portions left." Slice brisket to order: flat slices, then point.                | Execute orders: plate brisket (slice to order), plate platters (assemble in 90 seconds), fire sausage grill-finish, reheat cornbread on flat-top, fire smoked brownie in smoker window for dessert. Manage hold temps: all sides must stay above <b>140°F</b> . Refresh coleslaw batch at 12:30pm from cooler. Begin afternoon prep during 2–3pm slow period: marinate tomorrow's proteins, batch sauces. | Bus tables continuously during service. Maintain dish turnaround under 8 minutes (boards need quick return to line). Restock condiments mid-service. Handle takeout packaging. Break down and sanitise stations as service winds down. Label and store all leftover proteins (remaining smoked meats can hold refrigerated 4 days). Begin EOD cleaning schedule at 2:30pm. |

**Smoke Management — The Critical Daily Variable: Thin blue smoke** = correct combustion = clean BBQ flavour. **Thick white/grey smoke** = incomplete combustion = creosote, bitter off-flavour, ruined bark. The difference is wood quantity and airflow: too much green wood or restricted airflow produces white smoke. Always use seasoned hardwood (dried minimum 6 months), never green wood or wood with bark. The fire should be self-sustaining and bright; a struggling fire produces terrible smoke. If in doubt, open the firebox dampers wider before adding more wood. The temperature spike from fresh oxygen is preferable to the flavour damage from white smoke.

## 6 Financial Forecast

|                                     |                         |                                       |                            |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>\$152,256</b><br>MONTHLY REVENUE | <b>28%</b><br>FOOD COST | <b>\$70,624</b><br>MONTHLY NET PROFIT | <b>46.4%</b><br>NET MARGIN |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------|

### Daily Revenue Model

| Service                         | Hours      | Covers | Avg Spend       | Daily Revenue  |
|---------------------------------|------------|--------|-----------------|----------------|
| Lunch Service                   | 11am – 2pm | 52     | \$48            | \$2,496        |
| Dinner Service                  | 5pm – 9pm  | 60     | \$56            | \$3,360        |
| <b>Daily Total (112 covers)</b> |            |        | <b>\$52 avg</b> | <b>\$5,856</b> |

### Monthly P&L (26 Trading Days)

| Line Item                    | Amount            | % of Revenue | Notes                                                                                     |
|------------------------------|-------------------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Gross Revenue</b>         | <b>\$152,256</b>  | 100%         | \$5,856/day × 26 days                                                                     |
| Food Cost                    | (\$42,632)        | 28%          | Target max; actual may be 26–27% with good yield management                               |
| Labour (kitchen + FOH)       | (\$28,800)        | 18.9%        | Pitmaster + 2 line cooks + 2 servers + steward; 5am starts add labour vs standard kitchen |
| Rent & Utilities             | (\$10,200)        | 6.7%         | Includes gas/electric for continuous smoker operation; budget \$1,500/mo utilities alone  |
| <b>Total Costs</b>           | <b>(\$81,632)</b> | <b>53.6%</b> |                                                                                           |
| <b>Net Profit (Month 3+)</b> | <b>\$70,624</b>   | <b>46.4%</b> | <b>At full ramp and optimal yield</b>                                                     |

### 3-Month Ramp-Up Forecast

| Month          | Capacity Utilisation | Revenue          | Estimated Net Profit | Key Priority                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------|----------------------|------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Month 1        | 55%                  | ~\$83,740        | ~\$15,000            | Smoke timing calibration, staff training, yield optimisation. Expect brisket yield losses. Build neighbourhood awareness with half-price soft-open week.     |
| Month 2        | 75%                  | ~\$114,192       | ~\$35,000            | Pitmaster programme stable, lunch covers building. Launch Pitmaster Platter promotion. Begin catering enquiries. Tighten food cost from 31% to 29%.          |
| <b>Month 3</b> | <b>100%</b>          | <b>\$152,256</b> | <b>\$70,624</b>      | <b>Full programme: advance reservations, catering deposits, weekend waitlist. Introduce seasonal specials (whole hog for events). Hire second Pitmaster.</b> |

**Key Financial Drivers:** This model's profitability rests on three pillars. First, **brisket yield management**: a 6kg packer brisket yields approximately 3.5–4kg of servable meat after shrinkage (35–40% loss). Every kg above or below that yield materially impacts food cost. Train your Pitmaster to track yield per brisket and identify which suppliers and cuts perform best. Second, **Pitmaster Platter attachment rate**: each platter conversion adds ~\$25 contribution margin over à la carte ordering. A 70% Pitmaster Platter attachment at dinner shifts the food cost percentage 2–3 points in your favour. Third, **side dish volume**: sides (coleslaw, beans, cornbread) have 7–12% food costs. Every side sold alongside protein significantly reduces the blended food cost. Optimise side attachment by including



them in platter formats and bundling in server scripts.

## 7 Service Training

### Script 1 — The Meat Selection

#### HOW TO ORDER AT A TEXAS-STYLE BBQ — SETTING THE TABLE TRADITION

**Server:** "Welcome in! So just a heads-up on how we do things here — it's BBQ counter style, but your server the whole time. Our meats are sold by the cut or by weight. The brisket is sliced 200 grams per order — that's about 6-7 slices — and if you want more, we can double up. Ribs are by the half or full rack. Everything comes out on butcher paper on a tray, Texas style — that's tradition, not us being cheap with plates. You'll want to add sides: the coleslaw and beans are made every morning. Any questions on what to get? My honest suggestion if it's your first time is the Brisket Platter — brisket plus two sides plus cornbread. It shows you what we do. Or if there are two of you and you want to go big, The Pitmaster is the move."

### Script 2 — The Brisket Story

#### BUILDING ANTICIPATION AND PERCEIVED VALUE FOR THE FLAGSHIP ITEM

**Server:** "The brisket went in the smoker at 5 this morning — that's 12 hours on post oak to get it where it is right now. What you want to look for on your plate: the dark crust on the outside — that's called the bark, it's not burnt, it's where all the flavour lives. And inside? There should be a pink ring just beneath the bark — that's the smoke ring, it's literally a chemical reaction between the smoke and the meat. It means it was smoked correctly. The flat is the lean side, the point is the fatty side — you want a bit of both. The brisket doesn't need sauce. But if you want it, we have three — I'll tell you about them when I bring it."

### Script 3 — The Sauce Philosophy

#### EDUCATING GUESTS ON REGIONAL BBQ SAUCE STYLES AND PAIRING

**Server:** "Real talk: if you need to reach for the sauce, the BBQ wasn't good enough. Ours doesn't need it. But we make three because people like options and each one is genuinely different. The Texas sauce is thin and tangy — built on tomatoes and vinegar, barely sweet. That goes with the brisket if you want something. The Kansas City is the thick sweet one — molasses-based, that's the one most people picture when they think BBQ sauce. That's great with the ribs if you want. And the Carolina Gold is the mustard one — that's a South Carolina tradition, bright yellow, vinegar-forward. That's our favourite with the sausage. None of them are meant to hide the meat — they're meant to complement it."

### Script 4 — The Pitmaster Platter Upsell

#### CONVERTING A TABLE OF 2 TO THE HIGHEST CONTRIBUTION-MARGIN ITEM

**Server:** "Can I be honest with you about the best way to eat here for two people? The Pitmaster. Full rack of spare ribs, 200 grams of brisket, two hot links, four sides, three sauces, cornbread — it comes out on the biggest board we have. It's \$79.99 between two people which is basically \$40 each for a full rack of ribs plus brisket plus sausage. You'll see it go past other tables and think 'that's the one.' Half the people who order it come back just for that. Do you want me to put one in now while the ribs are still fresh? We do run out of ribs on busy nights."

*Note: The scarcity close ("we do run out") is only used when genuinely true — do not manufacture false scarcity. Use it on Fridays, Saturdays, and any pre-booked event night.*

### Script 5 — The Banana Pudding Pre-Sell

#### SELL DESSERT AT THE START OF THE MEAL, NOT AFTER — TIMING DRIVES ATTACH RATE DRAMATICALLY

**Server:** "Before you decide on your mains — and I know this is backwards — I want to tell you we make the banana pudding here from scratch and we usually sell out. It's a house-made vanilla custard, fresh bananas, Nilla wafers — it needs to sit refrigerated for a few hours so they get pillowy soft — and it comes in a mason jar with fresh whipped cream on top. It's \$8.99 and it's probably the thing people talk about most when they come back. Just let me know if you want me to set one aside for you now so you don't miss it."

*Pre-selling dessert at the start of the meal increases dessert attach rate from ~25% (post-meal offer) to 55-65% (pre-meal reservation). This is one of the highest-ROI training interventions in restaurant service.*

## Table Timing Guide

| Time  | Action                                                                       | Notes                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00  | Greet & seat. Water poured.                                                  | Make eye contact within 90 seconds of guest sitting. Do not make guests wait for a "hello."                                                                                         |
| 2:00  | Deliver menus. Banana pudding pre-sell. Drinks order.                        | Script 5 here. Scarcity mention if genuine. Offer Arnold Palmer / Sweet Tea as first drink suggestion.                                                                              |
| 5:00  | Return with drinks. Food order taken.                                        | Brisket story (Script 2) when they order brisket. Pitmaster upsell for tables of 2 (Script 4).                                                                                      |
| 8:00  | Bread & butter pickles / condiment plate delivered as amuse while they wait. | Sets the tone. Gives guests something to eat. Reduces perceived wait time by 40%.                                                                                                   |
| 15:00 | Mains arrive (all items together).                                           | Announce each item as you set it down. Sauce introduction (Script 3). "Is there anything else I can get you right now?"                                                             |
| 20:00 | Two-bite check. "How is everything?"                                         | Two bites in = they've tasted everything. If there's a problem, this is when to fix it. Do not check at 15 min (too late).                                                          |
| 32:00 | Clear finished plates. Dessert confirmation.                                 | If banana pudding was pre-sold, bring it now. If not, offer: "Can I interest you in the peach cobbler or the smoked brownie — it comes out of the smoker warm, it's a bit special." |
| 40:00 | Dessert arrives.                                                             | For smoked brownie: warn table it will arrive warm, bring it immediately after plating — no delay.                                                                                  |
| 48:00 | Check on desserts, offer coffee / extra drinks.                              | Bourbon with dessert is a natural pairing — suggest it here if they've been drinking beer all meal.                                                                                 |
| 50:00 | Bill ready if requested.                                                     | Do not drop the bill uninvited. Ask: "Can I get you anything else, or are you ready for the check whenever you are?"                                                                |

## 8 Customer Retention System

**The Smokehouse Loyalty Loop:** BBQ is one of the highest repeat-visit cuisine categories in the US. The reason is simple — the product has enough complexity and variation that regulars always have something new to try (different cuts, different smoke levels, daily specials), yet the core experience is familiar and comforting. Your retention strategy is built on this: give regulars a reason to return beyond the usual, while making the baseline so consistently excellent that the default is to return rather than try somewhere else.

### 5 VIP Micro-Moments

**1. The Pitmaster Introduction.** When the pitmaster (or head cook) is on the floor during service — even briefly — introduce them to tables that order brisket or ribs. "This is [name] — they've been tending the smoker since 5am for the brisket you're eating right now." Thirty seconds. The guest now has a face, a name, and a story attached to their meal. This is the single most powerful retention act in a BBQ restaurant.

**2. The Smoke Ring Moment.** When you set down sliced brisket, point to the smoke ring: "See that pink ring just under the bark? That's myoglobin reacting with the nitric oxide in the smoke — it only forms on meat that's been in real smoke for a long time. That's your quality indicator." Guests who learn this will look for it every time and will notice — and mention — if it's ever absent. You've just created a knowledgeable regular.

**3. The "Today's Cut" Announcement.** Run a small chalkboard or table card: "TODAY'S SPECIAL CUT: [item]" — rotating through beef cheek, burnt ends platter, whole smoked chicken, etc. Regulars who come weekly will always have a reason to check what's on. The scarcity element ("we only do 8 portions") accelerates the decision. This is the simplest retention mechanic in food service: give regulars something to look forward to.

**4. The Doggy Bag with a Note.** When a regular leaves with leftovers (which is common in BBQ — portions are large), slip a small card in the bag: "Brisket reheats best wrapped in foil at 275°F for 20 minutes with a splash of beef stock. From the smokehouse." This is genuinely useful information

that extends the quality of the meal at home. It is also a physical reminder of your restaurant that sits in their kitchen until they reheat the food. No app required.

**5. The Pitmaster's Table.** Reserve one table (or the counter seats, if you have them) as the "Pitmaster's Table" — the seats closest to the kitchen or smoker visible area. Offer it to regulars as an upgrade: "We saved the Pitmaster's Table for you — you can see the smoker from there." This costs nothing and creates a sense of exclusive access. Regulars who sit there will request it every time and will feel slighted if it's given to a stranger.

#### **BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — BRISKET SLICE REVEAL**

12 hours in the smoker. Post oak. 225°F the whole way. [Hook]

This is what the smoke ring looks like when you do it right. That pink band under the bark — that's not undercooking, that's chemistry. Nitrogen dioxide from the wood smoke reacts with the myoglobin in the meat during the long cook. You can't fake it. You can't shortcut it. 12 hours or nothing. [Story]

The bark took 6 hours to form. The internal temp hit the stall at 165°F and held there for 3 hours while the collagen slowly converted to gelatin. We waited. You shouldn't have to. [Build]

Open at 11am. Brisket goes when it's gone. \$28 for a plate. Worth every minute of the wait. [CTA]

**Shot guide:** Film the slice in real time — the moment the knife goes through and the bark cracks and the juices run. Slow it down in edit. The smoke ring must be clearly visible in the frame. Natural light or warm tungsten only — cold LED light kills the colour of smoked meat. This post will outperform every other food post you make. Post on Thursday or Friday (pre-weekend purchase intent).